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Reducing Post-Order Cancellations via Assurance Messaging

A behavioral A/B experiment to reduce uncertainty-driven user cancellations.

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

At a Glance

Objective
Reduce user-initiated food order cancellations post placement.

Insight
Most churn happens within 10 mins due to uncertainty.

Proposal
Test reassurance messaging on the confirmation screen.

Outcome
Lower cancellations with zero delivery impact.

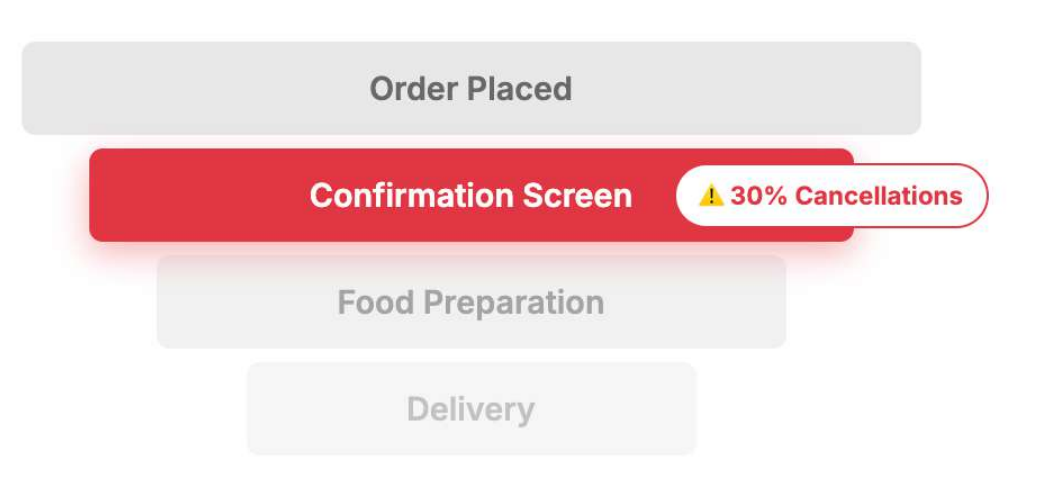
THE PROBLEM

The "Regret Window"

Observation: Users cancel orders shortly after placing them.

Timing: Primarily within the first 10 minutes (Matching Phase).

> **Why?**
> Lack of confidence. "Has the restaurant seen it? Is anyone coming?"


Order Placed
Confirmation Screen ⚠ 30% Cancellations
Food Preparation
Delivery

ROOT CAUSE ANALYSIS

Diagnosis: It's Psychological

Supply Issue?
❌
No. Capacity exists.

Pricing Issue?
❌
No changes.

Behavioral Issue?
✅
Uncertainty after commitment. Users feel a lack of control during the "matching" phase.

HYPOTHESIS

"Showing a short assurance message will reduce early cancellations."

Reassurance → Reduced Anxiety → **Fewer Cancellations**

EXPERIMENT SETUP

A/B Test Configuration

- **Type:** Randomized A/B Test
- **Population:** Eligible Food Orders
- **Split:** 50/50 at Order ID level
- **Duration:** 14 Days

Control (A)	Variant (B)
Standard UI	Assurance Msg

AUDIENCE

Target Population & Exclusions

✅ Included
- Users placing food orders
- Reach Confirmation Screen
- No cancellation in last 24h

❌ Excluded
- Cash-on-Delivery (COD)
- ETA > 60 Minutes

Excluded to avoid confounding variables like payment friction or extreme delays.

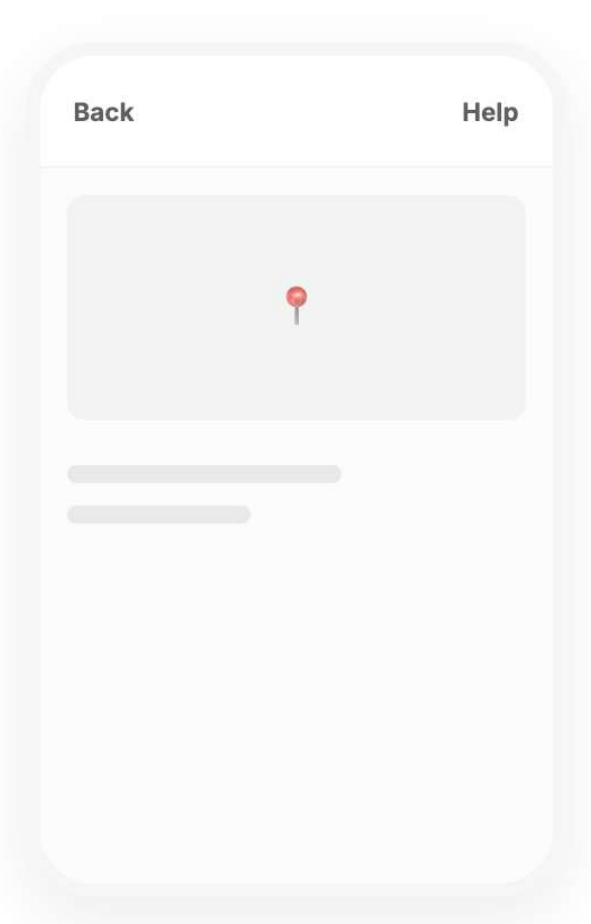
CONTROL (A)

Current Experience

Status: Passive & Uncertain.

The standard confirmation screen shows a map and a generic "Finding a driver" status. There is no feedback loop during the critical matching phase.

Result: High Anxiety



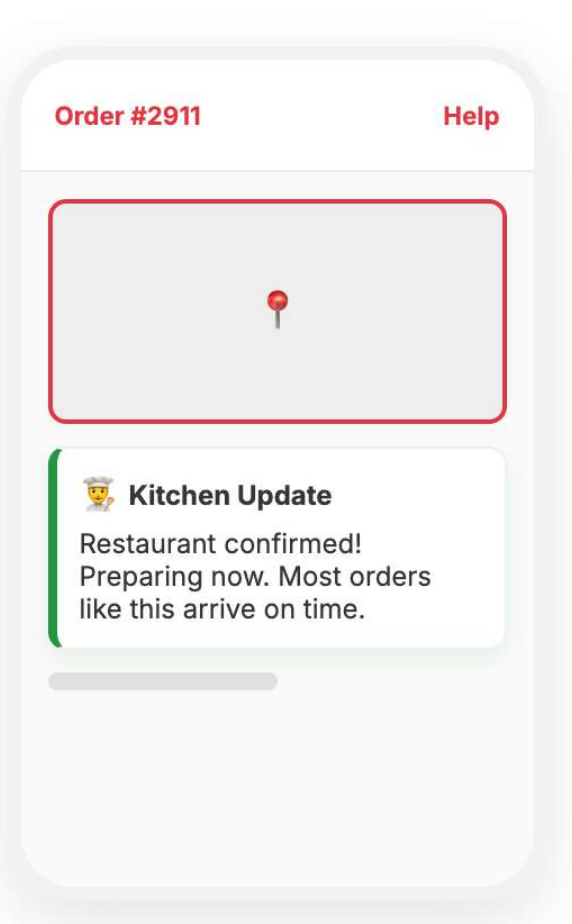
VARIANT (B)

Assurance Experience

Change: One short assurance message.

We inject a message immediately upon restaurant acknowledgement.

> **Micro-Copy:**
> "Your restaurant has confirmed the order and is preparing it now. Most orders like this are delivered on time."



Kitchen Update
Restaurant confirmed! Preparing now. Most orders like this arrive on time.

BEHAVIORAL MECHANICS

Why This Works

Progress Signaling
Shows system activity.

Social Proof
"Most orders are on time."

Commitment
Reinforces decision.

What We Avoided
- No monetary incentives
- No artificial ETA changes
- No operational changes

SUCCESS FRAMEWORK

Metrics & KPIs

North Star Metric

10-Min
CANCELLATION RATE
(User Initiated Only)

Guardrail Metrics

⭐ Rating	🎫 Tickets
Avg Delivery	Support Vol

Success means reducing cancellations **without** increasing support tickets or lowering ratings.

GO / NO-GO

Decision Rules

✅
Success Criteria
- **≥ 5%** relative reduction
- Stable guardrails

🛑
Failure Conditions
- No significant reduction
- OR Tickets **↑ > 3%**
- OR Rating drop **≥ 0.1**

ANALYSIS

Risks & Mitigation

RISK
Trust Erosion
If the message says "Preparing" but the order gets delayed significantly later, users may feel lied to, damaging long-term trust.

MITIGATION
Smart Triggering
- Tie message to actual **Restaurant Confirmation API** event.
- Gate message: Do not show for restaurants with poor historical prep-time adherence.

PROJECTIONS

Expected Business Impact

- **Fewer Cancellations**
  Direct Revenue Lift
- **Higher Completion**
  Better marketplace liquidity
- **Improved Confidence**
  Higher LTV for FTUs

Zero
OPERATIONAL COST
Purely a frontend product change.

NEXT STEPS

Execution Roadmap

PHASE 1
Launch Test
14-Day A/B experiment in Tier-1 cities.

PHASE 2
Analysis
Review metrics and guardrail stability.

PHASE 3
Rollout
Scale to 100% of non-COD orders.

PHASE 4
Iterate
Personalize by cuisine type.

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Thank You

"Small behavioral nudges at the right moment can unlock outsized impact."

Anshul Eskey